

Extraaa Dull

Too many showers, too much chatter, not enough play. IPL Season Two needs noodle straps.

Suck on it." Anyone who caught the tail-end of Shah Rukh Khan's advice to his critics on Day 4 of the Indian Premier League in South Africa would have been alarmed, especially if they hadn't caught the context. Mandira Bedi who was interviewing him, and had even worn a matching kafiye scarf for the occasion (he wore green, she wore purple, so charming) looked thunderstruck. The Bollywood superstar then went on to incriminate himself further, saying he was going to start calling Sourav 'Dada' Ganguly "dadass" instead of badass. Oral malfunction, anyone? Still, it was a trifle more entertaining than the IPL has been so far on SetMax, the channel that fought tooth and nail (and pocketbook) to retain the rights to show 37 days of Season Two, with Bedi behaving like Arun Lal in a smart dress and a late-in-the-day Katie Holmes bob and Sameer Kochhar trying to shock himself out of tedium with neon pink and royal purple silk shirts as he keeps the banter going with a valiant Lal. The sets, created in RK Studios, are a distinct improvement in size from last year's cubbyhole, but Kochhar and Lal look like deer caught in the headlights, especially when they have to fill the airtime in between showers. Not surprisingly, IPL Season 2 Day 1's cricket viewership has been lower (5.1 TRP for the first match and 5.2 for the second) than Day 1 of IPL Season 1 (7.2 for the only match of the day). Even *Extraaa Innings* has declined, from a 3.19 TRP in the pre-match analysis in 2008 to 2.67 in the pre-match broadcast in 2009. The post-match *Extraaa Innings* though is slightly higher—1.2 for 54 minutes in 2009 compared to 1.15 in 2008.

Not that SetMax seems to care, having been provided with a tactical time-out break within the match of seven-and-a-half minutes to fill with advertising and justify the absurd price tag of \$1.64 billion (Rs 8,200 crore) for nine years. They are charging Rs 4 lakh per 10 seconds, compared to Rs 2 lakh per 10 seconds for prime time soaps, so they may well up the revenues they earned last year (Rs 238 crore). But there's nothing extraaa exciting this year. Last year, the little boys and little girls who were posing as anchors had at least an air of bumbling freshness. This time, Bedi is trying too hard to be taken seriously as a cricket expert, analysing spin bowling with Chaminda Vaas and discussing strategy with Jonty Rhodes. *Indian Idols* Meiyang Chang and former veejay Gaurav Kapur are clearly the B-team, trotted out to talk to the fans and ask the cheerleaders to execute back flips. With a 34-camera set up, 10 more than last time, it also allows viewers to get closer to the players than ever before, which does have its drawbacks. You don't really want the children to hear their hero Virendra Sehwag swearing in Hindi and Fidel Edwards exchanging insults with Chris Gayle. But with 30 in-match advertisers, including two main sponsors and six associate sponsors, IPL Season 2 is still a big property. If not *Ek Desh*, *Ek Junoon*, it's still *ek aur desh*, *ek aur* prime time choice.

by Kaveree Bamzai

would be spent saying simply (and vaguely) that "Parents and school governing bodies will be encouraged to participate in the decisions on how to allocate scholarships".

Why do the same 'vip' faces keep appearing on our television screens? Because the producers have been ordered to put them there, that's why. And if you've paid tens of millions of dollars for a cricket team, then you deserve a bit of exposure—if publicity and exposure is your game.

The IPL is a fun tournament and will make excellent wallpaper in sports bars around the world in years to come. But South Africans are already beginning to see it for what it is, rather than what it portrays itself to be. It is an entertainment circus, rather than a sporting one, designed primarily to enable a very small number of fabulously



(LEFT TO RIGHT) BEDI, KAPUR, CHANG AND KOCHHAR AT A SETMAX PRESS CONFERENCE

wealthy people to become even wealthier.

A full page newspaper advertisement appeared nationwide last week depicting Sachin Tendulkar against Saurav Ganguly above the caption: "Whose side are you on?" The problem was, Tendulkar was alongside the Rajasthan Royals logo with Ganguly smiling next to the Delhi Daredevils motif.

The IPL. It's an Indian thing. And will forever remain so until the owners and administrators who so desperately want to become a "global brand" actually stop and think about what that means and how it can be achieved rather just splashing cash and blowing kisses to themselves in the mirror.

The writer is a well-known South African cricket journalist and a commentator.